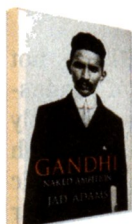


The Moral EXTREMIST

Gandhi's experiment with his own sexuality becomes his new biographer's delight



**GANDHI: NAKED
AMBITION**

by JAD ADAMS

Quercus

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By S. Prasannarajan

Believe me, there is nothing spectacular in the loin cloth." That was Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi in response to the comment that his sartorial transformation—from the young barrister in London in a wing collar and a top-hat to a bare-chested mendicant in loin cloth—was all show and no spiritual content. His "state of undress" was very Indian in its moral exhibitionism (or extremism), taking his cue from the sadhus and saints whose minimal requirement for the body was a manifestation of their asceticism. Gandhi's immediate provocation to abandon dhoti and jacket, though, was his own conscience: how could he be seen fully dressed when the poor who followed his call to burn all foreign cloth did not have enough khadi to cover themselves? So the most indulged fakir of the Orient who struck an awesome bal-

ance between his ideas and his actions was also a spectacular curiosity—and the most deconstructed one in the history of resistance.

Jad Adams, historian, biographer and television producer, too could not resist the man whose life story is an unparalleled narrative of empowerment—spiritual, sexual and political. In a life that was a pursuit of perfection, he made many contradictions of his moral practice look inevitable in the larger canvas of truth, which he maintained was never static. As Adams writes in the context of Gandhi's success in "exhorting a consent" from his wife on returning the gifts they received in South Africa, the first laboratory of Gandhism, "he assumed a position of absolute rectitude from the start, treating any objections as merely challenges to be overcome by greater acts of spiritual determination. The leaders of the Indian National Congress and representatives of the British government were later to observe this approach with some bewilderment." We hear the same bewilderment in the rustle of Adams' pages too. As he follows the trajectory of Gandhi's evolution, stretching from the harbour town of Porbandar to South Africa to colonial India, what bewilders him most is the force of his moral fundamentalism, almost verging on *schadenfreude*.

This extremism becomes more pronounced in his treatment of his family. His son Harilal wrote: "You have treated us as a ringmaster would treat the beasts of the circus... You have spoken to us never with love, always with anger." When he found out that his other son Manilal had sex with a married woman, he took the sin upon himself by fasting for seven days—and of course, the son had to fast with the father. Adams writes, "His disgust with sex sprang from his belief that he must control his strong sex drive or he could not accomplish spiritual greatness... Thanks to (his) early marriage, Gandhi had become tainted by carnality before he knew his own mind. Before he could reject it, he was burdened by those things of this world—his wife and children. Later he developed an indifference to the product of sex, his children, as if they tied him to the earthly world as living symbols of his carnal nature, and were of no import. When they became sexual beings themselves, his revulsion was almost palpable."

This is pop psychology, and for a historian

